

The Case for Studio C

A small operating company in Natchez, Mississippi has built the chat — and the team behind the chat — that prices artificial intelligence the way it should have been priced from the start. Software cheap. Humans premium. Same screen.

BY THE EDITORS

Natchez, Mississippi

It is past eleven on a Tuesday in Adams County and a woman in a small town in southwest Louisiana is typing into a chat window. She runs a four-room bed-and-breakfast on a side street off the main square. A couple has just asked, by email, whether she can hold their wedding the second weekend of October — the bride's mother has follow-up questions about a vegan menu, a sound permit she hasn't thought about since 2019, and the cancellation policy on a deposit that's already half-paid. The owner has been on her feet since six in the morning. She does not want to cross-reference a spreadsheet, look up a city ordinance, or remember whether she ever finalized last year's catering rider. She wants to answer the guest, and she wants to be in bed by midnight.

She types four sentences in plain English. The chat checks her calendar, looks up her own pricing, drafts a reply to the bride, flags the sound-permit question as a thing to verify in the morning, and offers — one sentence in — to escalate to a person who can call the city clerk on her behalf. She says yes. Within four minutes, a member of the Studio C team is in the same chat window, asking the two questions she didn't anticipate. By morning, the bride has her answer, the deposit is reapplied to the new booking, and the line item on her bill reads twenty-three dollars and fifty cents. The wedding she would otherwise have lost is back on her books for May.

This is what Studio C does. It is not a chatbot company. It is the operating company that runs the chat, the team that picks up when the chat hands off, and the billing engine that reconciles them on a single screen.

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What Studio C is

Studio C is a Mississippi-based operating company that runs a hybrid software-and-service product called Measurably Better Things. The product is one chat. The company is the team that makes the chat work, escalates what it can't, and bills both sides on the same meter. There is no portal. No ticketing system. No separate sign-in for support. The chat is the entire surface. Studio C is the entire company underneath it.

Three layers, in order. The chat answers from the customer's own data and the major language models — Claude, OpenAI, Gemini — picking the right one per request. Most things land here. When a request needs more than a single answer, the chat routes to one of thirty-plus specialist agents in the registry, each sharper at its job than a general-purpose model. When a request needs a person — a phone call, a vendor coordination, a deliverable that has to be hand-built, a judgment call that someone has to be accountable for — it escalates to the Studio C team. Studio C resolves it directly, or routes it out to a curated subcontractor network the customer never has to manage. One chat. One bill. One accountable group of people behind every request.

The transparency is the product. Customers see two meters at the bottom of every conversation: software tokens (cheap, a fraction of a cent each) and human tokens (premium, priced by the minute). The same screen shows what each piece of work cost and which side delivered it. No surprise bills. Optional caps. Pause anytime.

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 Interior of a recording studio inside a pole barn — mixing console, monitors, a Hammond organ on the back wall, kitchen visible through the doorway

The Studio C control room at the center of the property the company is building outside Natchez. The studio is where the company's name comes from — and where the work the company sells gets priced, tested, and shipped.

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Why this matters now

For two centuries, the things humans did better than machines were the things you charged a premium for. Analysis was expensive. Assembly was cheap. The premium lived in cognition. That trade is

inverting. A frontier model can now draft a contract, summarize an earnings call, and pass a medical board exam — all for less than a vending-machine coffee. What the model cannot do is the part that requires a person to be there. You cannot AI your way into being present at a closing, or into looking a vendor in the eye and telling them no, or into knowing the new line cook needs a ride home tonight because his car is in the shop. The premium is moving toward the things only humans can do.

Most software companies have not yet repriced for this. They sell the model layer at twenty dollars a month and treat the human layer as something you call about when the chatbot fails. Studio C has the order reversed. Software is cheap because software is now cheap. Human work is expensive because human work is what's left.

Inside the company this is called Inverted Intelligence. It is the through-line for everything Studio C ships — the pricing, the marketing, the radio show launching with the chat, the structure of the team itself. Same chat, two meters: software tokens at a thin margin over the underlying model, human tokens at the rate of a fractional senior operator. The customer sees both. The customer pays for both. The customer learns, on a single screen, what the actual cost of getting things done in 2026 looks like.

"Software is cheap. Humans are the premium. We bill them differently because they are."

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The product, in motion

A new customer arrives at the website on a Tuesday afternoon. She owns a small hospitality business in a corridor town somewhere — say, a bed-and-breakfast with eight rooms, or a venue with a kitchen. She signs up for the Standard tier at twenty dollars a month. Onboarding is twenty minutes. She uploads what she has — a guest list, a booking calendar, last quarter's invoices, a folder of photographs, a working draft of next year's pricing. The chat reads it, asks three clarifying questions, and says it's ready.

For the next two weeks she uses it the way she would use a sober assistant who never sleeps. She drafts emails. She runs numbers. She asks the chat to compare last October's bookings against this October's pace and flag anything unusual. She asks it to summarize the new state lodging tax rule that went into

effect in March. Every interaction is metered. Most cost less than a quarter. By the end of the second week she has spent about eight dollars on top of her subscription, and the running total sits at the top of the screen.

Then a guest cancels a wedding two weeks out. The deposit is non-refundable, but the bride is in tears, and the customer does not have time to write the four emails it will take to negotiate a partial refund, hold the date for the next inquiry, update the calendar, and notify the caterer. She types: *"I need help getting through this cancellation gracefully — can someone handle the back-and-forth?"* The chat tells her, in plain English, that this will escalate to a human at Studio C, that the human's time is metered at a higher rate than the AI's, and that the estimated cost is between fifteen and forty dollars. It asks her to confirm. She does. Within four minutes a person is in the chat. By the next morning the wedding has been rescheduled, the deposit reapplied, and the caterer notified. The line item on her bill is twenty-three dollars and fifty cents. The wedding she would otherwise have lost is back on her books for May.

This is the upgrade moment. By the end of the month she has moved from Standard to the Service tier — a hundred dollars, with thirty minutes of human time included and the human layer always one message away. She does not move because of a marketing campaign. She moves because she has used the human layer once and now she wants it on tap.

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What it costs

Pricing is the part of the product that most companies fudge. Studio C does not. There are six tiers, and each one exists for a specific kind of customer. There is no licensing fee. The tier subscription buys the chat door — and a baseline allocation of human-tokens. Beyond that, you pay for what you use, at a published rate, with the meter visible.

TIER	WHAT YOU GET	WHO IT'S FOR
Free \$0	The chat with the cheap, fast models. Limited specialist routing. No human layer.	Anyone curious enough to type something into a box.
Standard \$20 / month	Standard models — Sonnet, GPT-4o, Gemini Pro. The full router across thirty-plus specialists. Human help available pay-as-you-go.	Individuals and sole operators. Costs the same as ChatGPT. Does dramatically more.
Service \$100 / month TARGET	Premium models. Full router. Thirty minutes of human time included monthly. The human service layer is always one message away.	Small business owners, founders, single-property operators — the people who would otherwise be hiring their first part-time ops person.
Operator \$200 / month	Premium models. One to two hours of human time included. Custom dashboards built on demand.	Small teams and multi-property operators.
Business \$500 / month	Premium and tuned models. Workspace customization. Four to six hours of human time included. Custom routing rules.	Growing businesses, agencies, and vertical deployments.
Enterprise Custom	Dedicated infrastructure. Private specialist agents. A named service team with a service-level agreement.	Larger customers and partners.

The hundred-dollar Service tier is the one the company is built around. It sits in a price band that most consumer software companies have refused to enter. ChatGPT costs twenty dollars. Claude costs twenty dollars. Gemini Advanced costs twenty dollars. Each gives you exactly one model. None gives you a human. The Service tier costs five times that and gives you both. The argument for the upgrade is simple: a single thirty-minute escalation a month, handled by someone who actually finishes the task, is worth more to a working operator than a hundred extra messages to a chatbot.

The twenty-dollar Standard tier exists to hold the line. If the consumer market expects to pay twenty for an AI subscription, Studio C will charge twenty — but the customer gets the multi-agent router and a working escalation path, not just a single model behind a chat window. The Free tier is the funnel. Most features are visible-but-locked, and every wall the user hits points to twenty.

TWO STRUCTURAL DISCOUNTS

The human-token rate scales *down* as the tier scales up. Standard customers pay five dollars a minute for ops-level human work and ten for specialist work. Service customers get ten percent off both rates. Operator gets twenty. Business gets thirty. Enterprise contracts can reach fifty percent off, depending on volume. The bigger the monthly commitment, the more the customer signals they will actually use the human layer — and the better the team can plan capacity against it. Customers reap the savings.

Annual prepay is twenty percent off the monthly subscription line. Standard at \$192 instead of \$240. Service at \$960 instead of \$1,200. Business at \$4,800 instead of \$6,000. The human-token rate on usage beyond the included allocation does not change — annual customers already get the lower per-tier rate. The discount is the reward for predictability on both sides.

MODULES — PAY FOR WHAT YOU NEED

The base tier subscription buys the chat door. Customers add capability modules à la carte as they need them. Each module is a focused capability with its own monthly fee, often bundled with included human-tokens for the work that module will actually do. Light modules — email triage, calendar coordination, link-in-bio — start at twenty dollars. Standard modules with about an hour of monthly human time — bookkeeping ingest, customer-support triage, weekly reporting — run fifty to a hundred. Specialized modules with a dedicated person on the queue and several hours of monthly human time — video production, podcast editing, brand identity work — run two hundred to five hundred. High-touch modules with a multi-skill team rotation and ten-plus hours per month — full social-media management, agency-of-record work, dedicated CSM — run five hundred to two thousand.

The chat is always the front door. Modules just expand what the chat can do behind it. From the customer's perspective: *"I need this."* → *"We have a module for that. Activate it?"* No procurement cycle. No sales call. No twelve-month contract. Pay for what you need, the moment you need it. Pause when you don't.

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Who Studio C is

The team is small by design. Most of what would be a forty-person operations department at a conventional software company is handled by the chat itself, by the registry of specialist software agents, or by a curated subcontractor network the customer never has to manage. The customer sees one chat, gets one bill, holds one company accountable.

Chase Pierson is the founder and runs the technology, the editorial program, and the chat product. Tracy Alderson-Allen runs finance and the operating ledger. Amy Allen runs hospitality operations across the inn and the broader physical footprint. Elijah, in the Hudson Valley, is Chief of Staff and runs the Bearsville-side build. Miles handles production. Behind them, a registry of specialist agents — researcher, writer, planner, coder, analyst, designer — handles the second tier. Behind that, a curated network of contractors handles the third: photographers, editors, developers, vendors. We use Fiverr for fast specialty work. We have relationships with the slower, deeper kind. Everything that runs through the meter passes through Studio C first.

This is the part of the product that's hard to copy. Standing up a chatbot is now trivial — a college student with a credit card can do it in a weekend. Standing up a chatbot whose escalations are picked up by a competent human team that resolves the actual problem is much harder, because it requires building an operations practice as a peer to the engineering practice. Most AI startups are unwilling to do this. Studio C is willing because the operations team is the moat.

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The proof — Big Muddy

Studio C's first customer is itself. The team built the chat to run an existing Mississippi entertainment ecosystem the founders already operate — an inn on the river bluff in Natchez, a touring booking company, a quarterly magazine, a small record label, a streaming radio station, and a working photography practice. It is not a side project. It is a real operating business with real revenue, real cash flow, and real seasonal pressure. The mid-scenario forecast for the twelve months ending April 2027 is two hundred and eighty-three thousand dollars in consolidated revenue, with the inn carrying the year and the photography line second.

The argument for using the ecosystem as the first customer is operational, not promotional. If the chat cannot help the innkeeper rebook a wedding, it will not help an outside customer rewrite a listing. If the human escalation path takes six hours to close a ticket internally, it will take six hours externally, and no marketing will paper over that. The product is being beaten on by people who depend on it for their rent. Every workflow that survives gets shipped to the next customer. Every workflow that doesn't gets fixed before anyone outside the company sees it.

 A pole barn at golden hour, set into a clearing of pine trees, the long gravel approach lit by a low sun

Big Muddy Acres, Adams County, Mississippi. One specific project under the Big Muddy umbrella — a fifty-site RV park and tiny-house community anchored by the Studio C recording space. The cash flow funds the rest of the platform development.

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Big Muddy Acres is one specific line under that umbrella — a fifty-site recreational vehicle park and tiny-house community on a parcel of Adams County land outside the Natchez city limit. The parcel is being optioned now. Phase one — the RV pads, a shared bathhouse, a starter septic, and the studio barn that doubles as a recording room and Friday-night music space — runs between nine hundred and fifty thousand and one-and-six-tenths million dollars all in. At full occupancy the RV side alone generates three hundred thousand dollars a year. The studio at the center of the property is the recording studio. The recording studio is also Studio C.

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The proof — Scan2Plan

Studio C's first paying external customer is a scanning company. Scan2Plan came out of an earlier partnership and now operates as an independent vertical: it serves construction, architecture, and real-estate clients who need physical spaces captured at high fidelity, processed into usable models, and turned into the marketing material that wins their next contract. The projects are large — ten thousand to a hundred thousand dollars each — and the customer's attention budget is small. They do not have the time to write SQL against their own scan archive, or to hand-tune a press release the night before a pitch.

They sign up for the Business tier at five hundred dollars a month. Their data — scans, project files, client lists, deliverables, rate cards — gets ingested into the chat. From then on they ask the chat what they need. Generate a marketing piece for a project just delivered. Show me the revenue trend across the last six clients. Draft a pitch for a Boston job and price it against last year's comparable. The chat handles most of it at software-token rates. The harder questions escalate to the Studio C team. The platform fee is rounding error against the value of the chat handling lead intake, customer comms, and marketing material in the same place. That is the math that makes this tier a yes for them.

Scan2Plan becomes a vertical deployment of the same product, not a separate product. The customer brings their own data. Studio C wraps it in chat, service, and token billing. The shape generalizes — to real-estate brokers, to civic Main Street programs, to music labels, to anyone with a body of operational data they want to interrogate but no time to write the queries themselves.

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The unlock — Chicken Burke

The first artist deal at Big Muddy Acres is the first time Studio C will trade creative-services equity for real property. Robert "Chicken" Burke is a producer working with the small label. The standard arrangement would be a cash advance against the album — fifty thousand dollars, paid over the production cycle, recoupable against royalties that may or may not arrive. The proposed arrangement is different. The label values the record at fifty thousand dollars. Burke takes that value as either a full tiny house or a meaningful equity share in one at Big Muddy Acres. He becomes the first resident artist of the property. When he is at the house, he is at the house. When he is on the road, the house generates rental income that flows back to him.

The trade solves two problems that were in the notebook for months. The label needed a way to sign artists without cash it does not yet have. The property needed a marketing event powerful enough to get its first wave of attention. A musician trading a record for a tiny house is a story that runs in music press, real-estate press, alt-economics press, and lifestyle press at the same time. The trade is the press campaign. The press campaign sells the next ten residencies. The residencies populate the property. The property funds the next phase. The two business lines collapse into one.

This is not a charity model. Burke is signing because the math works for him. A cash advance disappears. A tiny house on appreciating Mississippi land does not. He becomes a resident of a community of people he wants to live next to, in a place where the climate does not freeze and the cost of living is a fraction of any major city's. The label gets a record without a check. The property gets a story. The story gets the next record. It is also the cleanest demonstration of the broader thesis: Studio C can price its creative output in tokens or in property, on the same ledger, with the same accountability behind it.

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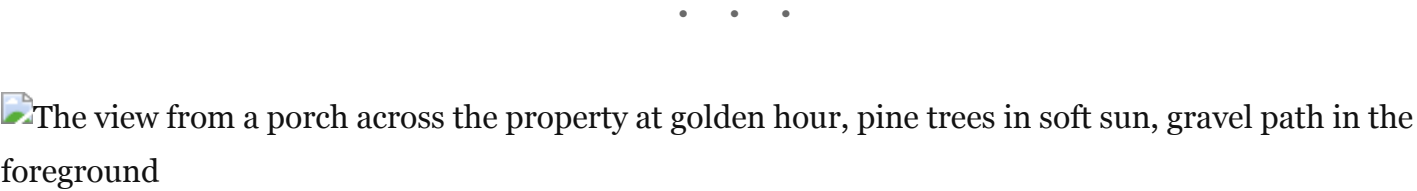
What ships next

The pilot rollout starts in Natchez this summer. The chat is being put in front of the people the company already knows — innkeepers, touring artists, magazine readers, the small commercial landlords on the bluff. The Service tier is what's being pushed; the cohort is small enough to learn what kinds of escalations actually come in. A second cohort opens in the Hudson Valley after that, around the Bearsville network the company has been quietly building near Woodstock. The two pilot regions cover

the customer profile Studio C most wants to understand: working operators in places that are not Silicon Valley, who need real help and have a real budget, but who are not large enough to hire a full-time ops person and not small enough to make do with a free chatbot.

Alongside the pilots, the company is launching an editorial program built around the same thesis. *Inverted Intelligence* is a weekly radio show — long-form conversations with operators, founders, and researchers seeing the inversion in their own work. The first episode is recorded with Chicken, and his trade is the cornerstone interview. The companion ad campaign runs as short video and static type cards. An AI voice cheerfully explains how to do something complicated in "ten easy steps." A person stares at the screen. A type card appears: *"You don't have a clue where to begin. We do. We do the rest."* The first three are shot with civilian friends, not actors. The campaign is the product positioning in compressed form. AI tells you. We do it.

The first cohort metrics decide when Studio C goes wide. The two numbers being watched are the conversion rate from Standard to Service, and the six-month retention rate of Service customers. If both come in above the internal threshold, the rollout opens to the broader Mississippi corridor and the Hudson Valley network by year-end, with vertical deployments — for scanning companies, for real-estate brokers, for civic Main Street programs — entering the pipeline shortly after.



The view from the south porch at the end of a working day. The product Studio C sells is the chat. The product Studio C has built around the chat is everything else.
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If any of this resonates

There are three ways into Studio C, and they are different conversations depending on who is reading.

THREE DOORS

- **If you operate a business** — try the Standard tier at twenty dollars a month and see whether it earns the upgrade to Service. The whole point is that the chat should pay for itself by the time you are done with the second week. If it does not, the meter on the screen will tell you so.

- **If you build or invest** — Studio C is raising capital to scale the team's service capacity and to accelerate the chat product roadmap. The mid-scenario operating business behind the company is at \$283,000 in year-one revenue with a clear ladder to the seven-figure number. Scan2Plan is the first paying external customer. The pilot cohort opens in May. Talk to Tracy Alderson-Allen, who runs finance.
- **If you cover this kind of thing** — the Chicken Burke trade and the Inverted Intelligence thesis are both stories Studio C is glad to talk about on the record. The pricing model is the lede. The Mississippi setting is the texture. The trade itself runs in early summer.

THE CHAT IS OPEN

If reading about the product is one thing and using it is another, the Standard tier is twenty dollars a month, no commitment. The chat is the engine. The bill is what you spend.

TRY THE CHAT →

Studio C · Operating company behind Measurably Better Things · Natchez, Mississippi